

LinkedIn India's AI engineering

Powering the future of hiring and jobs, according to **Malai Lakshmanan**

Jayesh Shinde | editor@digit.in

It's hard to escape the pull of LinkedIn, especially if you're a millennial or younger who wants to network online in a professional setting. "If you look at the kind of content people share – especially with all the advancements in tech – we're seeing strong engagement from members who come to learn what's happening in their field, how it impacts them, and how it will impact their jobs and careers," says Malai Lakshmanan, Senior Director and Head of India Engineering at LinkedIn, in an exclusive interview.

Popular misconceptions

When I ask him if LinkedIn is turning into Facebook – the irritating parts that perhaps take away from the network's professional feel – Lakshmanan sets the record straight. "We do get this question once in a while. To a certain extent, it depends on the quality of your feed – who you're connected to and what topics you're interested in. It's a reflection of that," he emphasizes.

"Some people I know say LinkedIn is the only social media network they're on," Lakshmanan explains. "And because it's their only social platform, they sometimes share something more personal with their community here. But for many, it's because they don't want the noise of other networks and find LinkedIn to be high-value."

Equating LinkedIn with Facebook isn't the only misconception about the professional social network, in Malai

Lakshmanan's perspective.

"One misconception I often see – especially among entry-level talent – is the belief that they can't get value from LinkedIn unless they already have a big network," he says. He recommends simple things like just creating a profile, exploring, expressing interests, following the right topics and people, and engaging with relevant content as indicators of a strong start on LinkedIn.

Indian engineering

"India has a meaningful presence across these layers. On the customer-facing side, a lot of our Talent Solutions work is run out of India," says Malai Lakshmanan, including several features and systems that millions of users interact with daily on LinkedIn – often without realising that teams in India are behind them.

"For example, the Easy Apply experience on LinkedIn is run by a team in India," he mentions. Lakshmanan also points out the work of making LinkedIn Recruiter connect neatly with the broader ecosystem is also driven out of India. "Teams in India power ingestion so jobs from customer platforms appear on LinkedIn. We also run Talent Insights out of India."



Malai Lakshmanan
Senior Director
and Head of India
Engineering at LinkedIn

Every action on LinkedIn – a connection request, a comment, a like, a follow – generates an event. Those events aren't just analytics trivia; they become the raw material for improving feeds, refining recommendations, and measuring product success. "That entire tracking infrastructure is actually run out of India," he says. In other words,

the systems that validate and route these events into LinkedIn's data pipelines are India-owned – and foundational to everything from business insights to data science experiments.

Rather than build a new system from scratch, the India team repurposed LinkedIn's universal schema registry to act as a GenAI prompt registry – essentially a central store of prompts that can be

monitored and governed, aligning with LinkedIn's "members-first" approach to data access. "A really small tweak," Lakshmanan calls it, but one that now powers a company-wide capability to keep up with AI-enabled workflows.

LinkedIn also receives large volumes of customer support queries. Lakshmanan says, "We're working on models that can interact conversationally, guide people to the right information, check satisfaction, and resolve issues faster – reducing dependency on traditional ticketing workflows."

If there's one disruption Lakshmanan is watching keenly for in 2026, it's not "GenAI" in the generic sense. "The rise of agentic experiences is particularly exciting," he says, "we may start seeing not just individual AI tools, but how they interact with each other to serve a purpose." **d**

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